



Behind the scenes: From Tejaswin's core team, S&C trainer Wayne handles his supplements and recovery protocols, while his wife Siddhi and sister Avantika are responsible for shoe changes, videography, and coaching cues during events. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Usually by this time, guys are pulling up on me. But not today. I was ahead of everyone except *him* — Yuma from Japan, reigning Asian champ, and one of the few Asians to have ever crossed 8000 points.

I crossed the line right behind him, glanced at the clock, expecting at least a 10.9.

11.2.

What???

I was stunned. I'd run faster with a groin injury four weeks ago. And now, at 100%, this?

But decathlon teaches you one thing — analyse later. For now, stay composed. You have to separate yourself from your emotions between events. That's what makes a decathlete.

Before I could even blink, we were at long jump — switched spikes, warmed up. Three jumps. You *must* register a mark. First jump — 7.28m. A solid start, but Siddhi told me I was a shoe-length behind the board. I had more in the tank. Second jump — 7.29m. Third jump — also close.

But not the 7.40m I had trained for. Not even close to the 7.37m I jumped while injured.

Something wasn't clicking.

Panic started creeping in. My strongest events were slipping. And it's not like I could make it up later — discus, vault... there's a ceiling to how much I can claw back there.

Shot put was next. I was spiralling. Legs jittery, hands shaky, mind in chaos. My competitors were all over 13m. My first two throws? 12.80, 12.81. One throw left. The pressure was enormous. Another bad event and I'm out of medal contention.

See, I'm not a balanced decathlete. My strength is Day 1. That's where I build my lead. Day 2? It's more about damage control. If I don't build that cushion on Day 1, I'm toast.

So, I stood in the circle. One last throw. I took a breath.

This is it.

Either I crumble, or I fight.

Glide. Explode. *GRUNT.*

13.79m.

A new PB. I was back!

Next was high jump — but I had two hours to reset. I dug around, trying to understand what was going wrong. Came across something called 'pre-start fever' — a psychological condition due to stress and nerves that mimics fatigue. Pair that with my three hours of sleep. Probably explains it.

Wayne and I made a plan. Lunch. Contrast shower — 30 seconds hot, 30 seconds ice, repeat 4-5 times. Caffeine. Nap. Wake up. High jump warm-up

It worked.

I crashed for 45 minutes. Best thing that happened that day. I woke up fresh, sharp. The PB in shot put had lit a fire. I felt like myself again.

High jump is my bread and butter. It's where I *must* gain ground. If I miss here, I'm a sitting duck on Day 2.

I opened at 2.01m — after most had bowed out. Cleared it easily. Then 2.04, 2.07, 2.10, 2.13, 2.16, 2.19 — all first attempts.

At one point, I saw Gulveer start the 10K. Between jumps, I clapped and cheered. It helped distract my mind — my little mental trick. But... okay, this may sound un-athlete-like: the 10K *got annoying*. The track was

swarming with skinny distance runners. Every jump, I had to look left and right, make sure no one was running through.

Still, 2.19m was a season best. I went for 2.22m — just missed it. As I took my last attempt, Gulveer crossed the finish. I was thrilled for him — but secretly wished the race had been scheduled differently. That 2.22m was within reach. (Sorry, Gulveer. I made up for it later by screaming my lungs out for the 5K.)

Last event of Day 1: the dreaded 400m. One lap of pain. I remembered legendary coach Clive Hart's 4 Ps of the 400m — *Push for the first 100, Pace the next 100, Position yourself the next 100, Pray the last 100*. I nailed the first three... but forgot to pray.

That last 100m hit like a truck.

50.10.

Not a bad score at the end of Day 1. But the real test? Morning of Day 2. When you have to hurdle over hip-height barriers that suddenly feel like Mt. Everest.

So post-400m: recovery mode. Massage, ice bath, food, compression gear, activation. In bed early. Slept like a rock.

Day 2 — woke up feeling much better. Body ached like I got hit by a bus — which is completely normal. If you can crawl out of bed, you're good to go.

Breakfast. Bags packed. Time to go again.

Hurdles were up first. The most unforgiving event when you're tired. I needed a solid race to create a cushion before vault. I was dialled in.

But warm-ups dragged. Heat 1